AD 1830, from donations made by Maharaja Ranjit Singh and his family members.

‘Maybe tonight’

For several months, arms and ammunition had been reaching the Golden Temple complex, hidden in trucks carrying provisions for langar. The police seldom checked these trucks, reportedly under instructions from the authorities concerned. No follow-up action was taken when one such truck was intercepted and found carrying Sten guns and ammunition. Young Sikh militants were being imparted weapons training inside the temple complex by ex-service men under the overall supervision of Shahbeg Singh.

Leaving the main Harmandir Sahib untouched, Shahbeg had started fortifying the vantage points of all buildings and structures within the Golden Temple complex and the surrounding private houses. Special attention was paid to the Akal Takht because of the presence of Bhindranwale and his armed men there. Every strategically significant building in the temple complex was fortified in a similar manner. Seventeen private houses surrounding the temple complex were in constant touch with Shahbeg Singh by means of wireless communication.

For Operation Blue Star, troops from the Meerut-based 9th Division were ordered to reach Amritsar by 30 May. It was commanded by Maj. Gen. Kuldip Singh Brar, who was a clean-shaven Sikh from the same Jat Sikh gotra (sub-caste) of ‘Brar’ as Bhindranwale. Originally from Faridkot, the Brars are in turn a sub-clan of the Sidhus.

After attending an important meeting in the afternoon of 2 June 1984, Kao returned to his office slightly late and looking despondent. One of his close confidantes (name withheld on request) who was waiting for him in his office, asked him the reason behind this demeanour. Kao significantly remarked that for the last couple of years he had been trying his best to stop things coming to such a pass but could not succeed. When asked to elaborate his cryptic remarks, Kao told that confidante he would be well advised